INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA AN OPEN READER

Edited and with an introduction by
David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

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Independent, Alternative, and Community Media: An Open Reader

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INTRODUCTION

The Promise and Vulnerability of Independent, Alternative, and Community Media

David W. Park and Meghan Grosse

When we think about "the media," we frequently imagine problems that we have with the media. Almost everyone is a critic of "the media." Independent, alternative, and community (IAC) media are different. There are defenses of and even manifestos on behalf of IAC media almost everywhere, and it is rare to encounter someone who speaks against the potential of IAC media. IAC media enjoy an unusually positive reputation in the hearts and minds of people across an eclectic array of political and social positions.

Free market libertarians see IAC media as essential components of a competitive marketplace where a multifarious range of options demonstrates how the lack of government interference can allow even smaller operations to become profitable, public-facing organs of culture and opinion. Here the libertarian ideal of multivocality—a thousand gardens blooming—is seen as the ideal means and ends for how media outlets fit into our lives. Picture a classic mid-twentieth-century newsstand, stocked with hundreds of different print publications from around the world, or imagine the World Wide Web itself, with its ponderously vast number of sites dedicated to all kinds of expression. These would be seen, in libertarian terms, as examples of a functioning free market in communication, a market that draws breath in large part from the vigor found in small media enterprises.

Conservatives who find the corporate media too "liberal" or "progressive" turn to IAC media as a way to get away from the mainstream media, who are held to be cozy with technocrats and other elites. Here the internet has received tremendous attention from conservatives,

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and the World Wide Web's association with conservative causes around the world has given voice to a populist belief in how IAC media outlets put the power back in the hands of those who agree with conservative values, uncensored by any elites.

Marxists see IAC media as exemplars of how media labor can be reclaimed and put in the service of the people in the name of opposition and resistance. Here IAC media are understood largely in terms of that Marxian concern for labor, and even for non-alienated labor, as the ideal of IAC media becomes aligned with the grander project of countering the ideological tools of the bourgeoisie. The slogan telling us we should "become the media" aligns with this vision of how IAC media outlets should operate.

Those who believe that media play an essential role in the sustenance of democracy see IAC media outlets as crucial supports in a Habermasian vision of how opinion ought to be worked out through public communication. Provision for the maintenance of IAC media is seen as essential to the sustenance of democracy. IAC media are seen as something like carve-outs that make autonomous journalism and other public-minded culture possible. These are media outlets as a refuge from the more profit-driven big media corporations, whose profit-focused incentives turn them away from democratic goals and public service.

Activists and intellectuals who represent feminist, Black radical, Indigenous, working class, and other movements all make use of independent media outlets and make plain their belief in the necessity of media being in the hands of the people. IAC media operate here as repositories of hope and power, collecting resources for representation of worldviews frequently ignored by corporate media, countering their othering tendencies, and generating community through the distribution of messages that come from inside their own world.

Scholars around the world rely on publishers of books and journals so that they can share their work with each other and with the broader public. As the biggest academic publishers pursue an accelerated strategy of consolidation and market lock-in, installing their own vision of what is profitable as what will suffice for academe, many scholars find themselves turning to an academic version of IAC media in the hope of finding publishing venues that reflect scholars' own interests and that foster a more organic connection to academic work than can be found in working with the big publishers. [1]

Large, for-profit media corporations frequently regard IAC media as bearers of new possibility for their own operations, in the form of ideas to be co-opted or as properties to be acquired. With a prospector's gaze, these dominant media operations see promise not in IAC media in and of themselves, but in terms of what they might offer to their own future profitability, if the material could be "scaled" or distributed to a broad enough audience. It is a familiar narrative in media history, where a small media organization brings something new and dynamic—the next big thing—to light, and then gets absorbed into the dominant media.

This widespread agreement regarding the beneficence of IAC media is the result of an unusual alignment of different philosophical and political standpoints. The sentiment that brings them into alignment is a widespread agreement that large, corporate, mainstream media outlets are not doing things very well. This is of course a well-worn idea in media studies. If anything can be expected to generate widespread agreement among communication and media studies scholars, it would be the idea that the media—understood frequently

[1] We would be remiss if we did not point out that mediastudies.press—the press for this open reader—aligns with these values.

(and somewhat justifiably) to be a shorthand for large, corporate-controlled media operations—create problems. Independent, alternative, and community media become what we can salvage from the wreck of "the media."

IAC outlets occupy an unusual space in scholarship and pedagogy. Though there is certainly abundant scholarship concerning IAC media, these tend not to attract as much attention as the corporate alternative, in large part because they simply lack the power of large media entities. The decisive media operations and cultural phenomena whose actions are most noticeable and powerful—from Facebook to Disney to Beyoncé to federal regulatory boards—take up much of the space of media studies scholarship. This makes perfect sense, of course; media scholarship *ought* to address the most visible issues we face, and while some parts of the humanities struggle to explain why they focus so much on less prominent parts of the culture, for better or for worse, media studies has long been called to the more prosaic and powerful currents in media culture.

In the classroom, this focus on corporate media makes sense in much the same way. Students enroll in media studies courses, instructors teach them about something called "the media," and so our courses often follow the same cues that our scholarship does, with a focus placed largely on dominant media phenomena. One result is that many of the schools of thought that get regular treatment in media studies courses take on a critical cast; the media are posed mostly as a problem. Media studies courses become litanies of what has gone wrong with the media. Courses that focus on journalism detail the dysfunctions and problems in journalism, where we find a target-rich environment. Courses that focus on critical political economy are shot through with descriptions of large corporate entities exerting themselves against all comers. Cultural studies courses usually touch on the potential for oppositional views, but often make this case on a dreary-if-relevant backdrop of cultural domination. In short: For some very good reasons, media studies classes are often excursions in plumbing the dystopian possibilities of media systems and their effects on individuals and societies.

In light of this downcast tendency in media studies—a tendency that has arguably become even more pronounced in recent years, as authoritarianism's global spread becomes a direct challenge to the very idea of critical thinking—something that this open reader can do is provide material for courses that emphasize something more upbeat. The selections in this open reader do not treat IAC media as uniformly or perfectly good things, nor do we hope to uphold any such myth. Still, IAC media are largely focused on the kinds of hopes that we have about how we communicate with each other. The media considered here link up in direct and obvious ways with hopes for democracy, political progress, self-expression, community formation, conflict resolution, advocacy for neglected groups, mutual understanding, cultural innovation, group advocacy, group representation, and much more. A media studies curriculum ought to include the study of IAC media because they remind us that the media themselves are not just a problem, not just a monolithic agent of capitalist, misogynist, *(neo)* colonial domination.

One potential problem with a focus on smaller media outlets, many of them unknown to all but a few, is that these outlets will not be as familiar to students or their professors. So much the better. By considering termite media and not just white elephant media,[2] we get an

[2] See Manny Farber, "White Elephant Art vs. Termite Art," *Film Culture*, no. 26 (Winter 1962): 9–13.

opportunity for a ground-up perspective, one that reveals a more inspiring set of possibilities and potential than an exclusive focus on the dominant. The IAC perspective does not rid us of dilemmas—indeed the dilemmas run fast and deep in the world of IAC media—but even these dilemmas give us a different perspective for understanding than we would have if our attention remained fixed on dominant media.

Because definitions of IAC media involve perilous slippage, many points of disagreement, and a challenging variety of theoretical emphases, it would be worthwhile to consider in some detail how scholars have defined what we have called—in a nod to that diversity—independent, alternative, and community media. Our goal in this definitional survey is not to arrive at precise or correct definitions, but to establish some of the theoretical parameters at work in the scholarship. The scholarly conversation about IAC media has been going on for a long time in a wide variety of contexts, and there is as much to be gained from noticing the differences and points of contention as there is in noticing the significant points of overlap. For the purposes of this reader, we take IAC media to be part of an ongoing conversation. This conversation involves certain ways of looking at the media, and cues particular problematics and potentials of IAC outlets. Because our goals are broad and pedagogical, and because we are charting an expansive global conversation, we do not offer a specific definition of IAC media. Instead, we review definitions of independent, alternative, and community media expressed in the literature. One can find common themes across all of these definitions, while noting the conceptual fault lines too.

Independent Media

One quickly finds the phenomenon of "independent media" to be a multi-dimensional affair. James Bennett helpfully identifies how media "independence may be present, or contested, at one or all of" four sites. The first of these is the sociopolitical, where status as independent media is taken to refer to a certain independence from governments and to the need for voices independent from those governments to play a role in self-government.[3] The second site is the industrial, where independent media are understood to operate "with 'freedom,' from (excessive) state regulation or commercial imperatives" and from "(in reality or rhetorically) the mainstream."[4] The third site is the formal, "whereby independent media produce and mobilize an ensemble of particular aesthetic and taste codes." Many of these codes are difficult to navigate without the requisite cultural capital, so we find talk of media independence lending itself to "niche and elite tastes." The fourth and final site Bennett identifies is the "rhetorical or discursive," which "operates across the other three sites and is mobilized by producers, audiences, regulators, businesses and a range of vested interests in declaring this or that formation to be 'independent media.'" Here the very idea of media independence, a complex and weighted rhetorical construct, is the thing at play, and we often find this ideal

[3] James Bennett, "Introduction: The Utopia of Independent Media: Independence, Working with Freedom and Working for Free," in *Media Independence: Working with Freedom or Working for Free?*, ed. James Bennett and Niki Strange (Routledge, 2015), 3.

[4] Bennett, "The Utopia of Independent Media," 3–4.

of media independence "expressed as a utopian ideal within which a particular 'independent media' might operate—for example, the free press, or 'Indie' music or film." [5]

The sociopolitical site of independent media frequently finds purchase in considerations of independent media that emphasize outlets' functional independence from governments. We often find this usage of the term "independent media" [6] in parts of the world where governments play a prominent and direct role in shaping communication. James Zaffiro uses this term to explain broadcasting reform in Botswana, [7] and Mercy Wambui describes how "independent media" are a response to an "urgent need to move from top-down, state-driven propaganda to message-driven and participatory forms of dialogue and expression." [8] Jenifer Whitten-Woodring uses "free media" and "independent media" interchangeably, as a way to consider "media free of legal restriction, free of censorship or intimidation/violence, free from financial limitations by government, and encouraging plurality of ownership, monitoring function of journalists, coverage of controversy, and work on behalf of/representing marginalized voices." [9] Peter Eng relays how journalists working for independent media outlets had begun "enlarging the political space in Southeast Asia, a space that has been dominated by authoritarian governments." [10] And Oray Egin employs this same familiar formulation to describe Turkey's prime minister Recep Tayyip Erdogan's attack on independent media. [11] The opposition in this understanding of independent media is rather stark: Good independent media are treated as the cure to bad government-run media.

When searching for non-scholarly sources related to "independent media," we found numerous articles that incorporated this independence-from-the-state understanding. This view is particularly common in Western journalism articles concerning news reporting outside of the US and Western Europe. This definition of independent media—especially independent journalism—as hinging on freedom from state control poses a problem. The presumption that independence from the state makes media outlets meaningfully independent can be criticized as a rather shortsighted and US-centered vision. In his treatment of Brazilian journalism, Afonso de Albuquerque connects this concern for independence from the state to what he calls "US/UK Fourth Estate models of journalism." [12] Albuquerque traces how the very idea of "independent journalism" in Brazil came to be coopted by a neoliberal understanding of commercial journalism as meaningfully independent simply because it was not controlled by the government. When the sociopolitical site of independence is identified as non-state-run media, we find the idea of independence itself doing work to elide or conceal corporate control.

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[5] Bennett, 4.

[6] In this context, the term "independent journalism" is often used instead of "independent media."

[7] James Zaffiro, "Broadcasting Reform and Democratization in Botswana," *Africa Today* 47, no. 1 (2000).

[8] Mercy Wambui, "Media Diversity Towards Democratisation: New Forms of Societical Organization," *Agenda: Empowering Women for Gender Equity* 72 (2007): 97.

[9] Jenifer Whitten-Woodring, "Watchdog or Lapdog? Media Freedom, Regime Type and Government Respect for Human Rights," *International Studies Quarterly* 53, no. 3 (2009): 598.

[10] Peter Eng, "The Media and Democratization in Southeast Asia," *Current History* 94, no. 614 (1997): 437.

[11] Oray Egin, "The Silence of Surrender: Erdogan's War on Independent Media," *World Affairs* 176, no. 4 (2013).

[12] Afonso de Albuquerque, "Journalism and Multiple Modernities: The Folha de S. Paulo Reform in Brazil," *Journalism Studies* 20, no. 11 (2018): 1546.

While the sociopolitical site of independent media tends to be focused on particular political contexts, the industrial site of independent media is more widespread. Michael Azzerad points to the "punk ethos of DIY, or do-it-yourself" that characterizes independent rock music.[13] Independent film, likewise, has been defined in terms of the "financing, production and artistic intent" that defines filmmaking that "exists in between avant-garde and experimental films," on the one hand, "and studio-financed Hollywood production," on the other.[14] Yannis Tzioumakis acknowledges, and then critiques, the idea that "independent filmmaking consists of the low-budget projects of (mostly) young filmmakers with a strong personal vision," quite distinct from the big-budget Hollywood-style filmmaking.[15] Industrial location also plays a major role in how Geoff King defines independent filmmaking; he describes how many independent films are "produced in an ultra-low-budget world a million miles from that of a Hollywood blockbuster."[16]

The same industrial approach to defining independent media can be found in the worlds of comic books and video games. Gamal Hennessy defines "independent comic book publishing" as something done "without the support or assistance from any larger corporate owner or third party publisher," which he connects to "creator-driven comic book publishing" and "freelance comic book publishing."[17] In the world of video games, Paulo Ruffino outlines the broadly-shared understanding that "independent video games were made by individuals or small companies, with limited budgets, and distributed privately or via online platforms bypassing traditional publishers," an understanding that Ruffino finds disappointing given that it is unclear how this movement's "new modalities of production" represented any meaningful emancipation.[18] Nick Dyer-Witheford and Greig de Peuter find independent video game development to be swamped in a market where the video game publishers have inordinate power,[19] a situation they situate in terms of Vincent Mosco's description of how independent operators in media "absorb high product risks and labor costs for the giants, which maintain control over the critical areas of finance and distribution."[20]

The third site of independence that Bennett applies is the formal. Here the distinctions tend to be more implicit than in the first two sites (sociopolitical and industrial). We find numerous discussions pertaining to how independent media come to be identified in terms of their formal distinction from the content offered by large media corporations. Ryan Hibbett "draws a parallel between indie rock and high art, both of which depend upon a lack of popularity for their value, and require specialized knowledge to be fully appreciated."[21]

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[13] Michael Azzerad, *Our Band Could Be Your Life* (Back Bay Books, 2001), 6.

[14] Linda Badley, Claire Perkins, and Michele Schreiber, "Introduction," in *Indie Reframed: Women's Filmmaking and Contemporary American Independent Cinema*, ed. Linda Badley, Claire Perkins, and Michele Schreiber (University of Edinburgh Press, 2016), 5.

[15] Yannis Tzioumakis, *American Independent Cinema*, 2nd ed. (Edinburgh University Press, 2017), 1.

[16] Geoff King, *American Independent Cinema* (Bloomsbury, 2014), 2.

[17] Gamal Hennessy, *The Business of Independent Comic Book Publishing* (Nightlife Publishing, 2020), 12.

[18] Paolo Ruffino, "After Independence," in *Independent Videogames: Cultures, Networks, Techniques and Politics*, ed. Paolo Ruffino (Routledge, 2021), 2.

[19] Nick Dyer-Witheford and Greg De Peuter, *Games of Empire: Global Capitalism and Video Games* (University of Minnesota Press, 2009), 41.

[20] Vincent Mosco, *The Political Economy of Communication: Rethinking and Renewal* (Sage, 1996), 109.

[21] Ryan Hibbett, "What is Indie Rock?," *Popular Music and Society* 28, no. 1 (2005): 55.

Independent filmmakers, he adds, are those who "create films that stand against the crass commercialism of mainstream Hollywood while often pushing the envelope in terms of subject matters and representation."[22] Independence can be lined up with the "formal/aesthetic strategies" of independent films, wherein these films "adopt formal strategies that disrupt or abandon the smoothly flowing conventions associated with the mainstream Hollywood style" and "offer challenging perspectives on social issues."[23] Something similar can be said about the "distinctive aesthetic traits" of independent games.[24]

The fourth and final site of media independence, the rhetorical or discursive, reminds us that "independence" is a stake in the game, a site to be claimed. Here there is a more pronounced awareness that media independence is put forward as a premise in some argument on behalf of independent media. "Independent film" is a label that comes to be attached even to films produced by major corporations.[25] Alisa Perren describes how "indie film" became a convenient marketing label to brand a particular type of movie for Hollywood studios looking to extend their reach into certain markets.[26] Independent rock music, likewise, can be seen as "a marketing tool."[27] It is the "relationship to the broader social, cultural or ideological landscape" that subtends the "independent" identity of independent films.[28] The rhetorical or discursive site demands an appreciation of the contradictions of media independence, the impossibility of truly nailing down what independence must always mean. These contradictions are indexed by the sheer difficulty in settling on a "fixed definition of independence"; definitions of independence range widely "across various actors involved and their temporary and fluctuating interpretations of their own work" in indie games.[29] Laine Nooney addresses how "indie" comes to serve as "a referent for a curious balancing act between art and business, commerce and creativity." This balancing act generates a host of rhetorical strategies of independence, poised as it is among "varied aesthetic imperatives about the contours of 'personal expression,' a kind of neoliberal hucksterism around the power of individual creativity, and the endlessly scalable conditions which drive our creative desires."[30] At the rhetorical and discursive site of media independence, we are reminded that there is no essential "independence" that operates autonomously in any particular media context, to be measured with scientific precision. Media independence is always already a claim.

Alternative Media

Media deemed to be "alternative" encounter issues that run parallel to the "independent" designation. Certainly, as with "independent" media, there are nagging concerns rooted in

[22] Tzioumakis, *American Independent Cinema*, 1.

[23] King, *American Independent Cinema*, 2.

[24] Ruffino, "After Independence," 2.

[25] Tzioumakis, *American Independent Cinema*, 3.

[26] Alisa Perren, *Indie, Inc.: Miramax and the Transformation of Hollywood in the 1990s* (University of Texas Press, 2012).

[27] Hibbett, "What is Indie Rock?," 55.

[28] King, *American Independent Cinema*, 3.

[29] Ruffino, "After Independence," 2.

[30] Laine Nooney, "The Indie is Now: Thoughts on Bennett Foddy's Indiecade East Keynote," LaineNooney.com, June 21, 2014.

demarcation. John Downing decries the term "alternative media" as being "almost oxymoronic" because "everything, at some point, is alternative to something else."[31] It is important, he adds, that we not "idealize alternative media as 'free spaces' that are completely liberated from the day-to-day structural considerations" at work in almost any media operation.[32] Alternative media are often run with commercial constraints in mind, which may make them more like dominant media operations than we might prefer. Linda Jean Kenix notes that "commercially minded alternative media are naturally cognisant of economic pressures and fiscally plan their operations in such a way to (hopefully) ensure their own continued existence—even if the chance of economic sustainability is quite small."[33] As with "independent media," we find ourselves on conceptual terrain where distinctions cannot be taken for granted.

A common issue at work in alternative media definitions concerns their contribution to a broadened and more multivocal media sphere. The common view is that alternative outlets are more inclusive, with a wider range of points of view. The focus on multiplicity can be found in Chris Atton's argument that alternative media "are not simply concerned with presenting a different version of the world; taken together, they offer *multiple* versions of the world."[34] As a rubric, "alternative media" becomes a rather content-neutral way to refer to the range of possibilities for expression. As media that are more easily accessed by creators, alternative media benefit from what Mike Mowbray calls "logics of participation,"[35] wherein accessibility involves "offering broad-based, direct participation in media production, especially to those least well represented in mainstream media and the discourse of dominant publics."[36] James Hamilton argues that the "collective value" of alternative media can be found in "their exploration of new forms of organizing more participatory techniques of media and more inclusive, democratic forms of communication."[37] Alternative media are, then, widely viewed as an important part of what makes a broader cultural conversation possible.

Connected to this idea is a slightly more dynamic appreciation of how alternative media stimulate innovation and "the new," particularly in the context of art.[38] So one can find descriptions of the "heterodox-creative logics" of alternative media, which are "exemplified in a concern with the production of 'culturally radical' content and aesthetic innovations."[39] Though there is reason for skepticism about a connection between innovative aesthetic com-

[31] John D. H. Downing, *Radical Media: Rebellious Communication and Social Movements* (Sage, 2001), ix.

[32] Linda Jean Kenix, "Commercialism and the Deconstruction of Alternative and Mainstream Media," in *The Routledge Companion to Alternative and Community Media*, ed. Chris Atton (Routledge, 2015), 70.

[33] Kenix, "Commercialism and the Deconstruction of Alternative and Mainstream Media," 68.

[34] Chris Atton, "Introduction: Problems and Positions in Alternative and Community Media," in *The Routledge Companion to Alternative and Community Media*, ed. Chris Atton (Routledge, 2015), 2.

[35] Mike Mowbray, "Alternative Logics? Parsing the Literature on Alternative Media," in *The Routledge Companion to Alternative and Community Media*, ed. Chris Atton (Routledge, 2015), 23.

[36] Mowbray, "Alternative Logics?," 24.

[37] James F. Hamilton, "What's Left? Towards a Historicized Critique of Alternative Media and Community Media," in *The Routledge Companion to Alternative and Community Media*, ed. Chris Atton (Routledge, 2015), 373.

[38] Understood this way, art is nothing but a set of media relations. There is an obvious way in which this is true. The term "media" is found quietly at operation in almost all discussion of art, and art departments at colleges and universities are almost always divided according to media (e.g., painting, printmaking, sculpture, photography, and of course "mixed media"). In a less obvious manner, art involves the same structures that other media do. Art galleries and museums are media outlets much like other media outlets, and must be sustained and imagined like other media outlets.

[39] Mowbray, "Alternative Logics?," 27.

munication and meaningful political liberation, it is still worthwhile to appreciate how artistic innovation across all media—from painting to motion pictures to music—depends to a great extent on how those media systems are imagined and structurally arranged.

Alternative media can be defined in terms of how they stand in opposition to dominant media and cultural formations. Here, beyond giving us new voices or a broadened sense of what exists, alternative media come to be associated with, and valued for, their alignment with that which cuts against the dominant way of doing, thinking, or feeling. There is a kind of dialectical appreciation of how alternative media stand opposed to what is dominant. Nick Couldry and James Curran make this an explicit definitional criterion for alternative media when they declare that "what we mean by 'alternative media'" is "media production that challenges, at least implicitly, actual concentrations of media power, whatever form those concentrations may take in different locations."[40] As he lays out the rationale for considering an alternative internet, Chris Atton defines alternative media as "a range of media projects, interventions and networks that work against, or seek to develop different forms of, the dominant, expected (and broadly accepted) ways of 'doing' media."[41] John Downing's description is quite similar to this, with his notion that alternative media "generally serve two overriding purposes: (a) to express opposition vertically from subordinate quarters directly at the power structure and against its behavior; (b) to build support, solidarity and networking laterally against policies or even against the very survival of the power structure."[42] Robert Hackett and William Carroll describe the "ideal" alternative medium as "progressive" and "explicitly opposed to particular axes of domination (corporate capitalism, heterosexism, racism, state authoritarianism)," while also direct about its own "stance of advocacy rather than pseudo-'objectivity.'"[43] Beyond just offering space for new voices, then, alternative media are seen as offering content and modes of being that work against, criticize, oppose, undermine, and denaturalize the dominant way of doing media.

This oppositional tendency in treatments of alternative media can very easily turn into a presumption of the effect of alternative media on the world around them. The impact of alternative media is an important locus of concern. There is tremendous skepticism regarding the extent to which alternative media are in fact effective in bringing about change in the broader world. Scott Uzelman urges caution when sorting out effects. He remarks on the "determinism of technique" that often shapes our understanding of alternative outlets, a determinism that presumes that "certain techniques of organization and struggle," including those exemplified by alternative media, "will produce emancipatory outcomes."[44] A similar concern is raised by Christian Fuchs, who warns about the "danger that small-scale local alternative projects will develop into psychological self-help initiatives without political relevance

[40] Nick Couldry and James Curran, "Introduction and Theoretical Perspectives," in *Contesting Media Power: Alternative Media in a Networked World*, ed. Nick Couldry and James Curran (Rowman & Littlefield, 2003), 7.

[41] Chris Atton, *An Alternative Internet: Radical Media, Politics, and Creativity* (University of Edinburgh Press, 2004), ix.

[42] Downing, *Radical Media*, xi.

[43] Robert Hackett and William Carroll, *Remaking Media: The Struggle to Democratize Public Communication* (Routledge, 2006), 58.

[44] Scott Uzelman, "Dangerous Practices: 'Determinism of Technique' in Alternative Media and Their Literature," *International Journal of Media and Cultural Politics* 7, no. 1 (2011): 22.

that are more bourgeois individualist self-expressions than political change projects."[45] It is certainly a good idea to remain on watch for assumptions about the effects of alternative media in the absence of evidence.

Even with a healthy dose of skepticism, it is good to consider how alternative media have been assayed in terms of their effects on the world. Mike Mowbray helpfully sorts out two "levels of impact" that get tied to alternative media: "(1) subjective individual and immediate group-level impacts for participants in production; (2) broad social and political impacts related to public-formation, group representation, political deliberation, contestation and social movement formation/mobilization."[46]

These kind of "inward" effects on the people making alternative media, and "outward" effects for the world around these outlets, give us some sense of how to conceptualize potential effects. The presumption of smaller-level effects can be found, for instance, in the idea that alternative media provide a space for those who stand against a dominant order. "Alternative comics and fanzines," for instance, have been posited as "'virtual' meeting spaces where producers and readers unite in 'communities of dissent.'"[47] Here it is the real-life drawing together of people in the name of some shared meaning or cause—the founding or sustenance of a community—that is the effect. Alternative media can also be considered in terms of the connections they have with the rest of the world. The situation has been compared to Deleuze and Guattari's idea of the rhizome, which "ceaselessly establishes connections between semiotic chains, organizations of power and circumstances relative to the arts, sciences and social struggles."[48] Alternative media can, correspondingly, be conceptualized in terms of connections they can "establish with (segments of) the state and the market, without losing their proper identity and becoming incorporated and/or assimilated."[49] The effects of alternative media, in other words, can be registered through how they come to be connected, not just to small networks of individuals, but to much of the rest of the world through the workings of rhizome-like—non-linear, horizontal—networks of relations that inevitably connect alternative media to more sweeping power relations.

An important intervention in the conceptualization of alternative media can be found in Nick Couldry's careful attention to how "voice" comes to matter. We are of course accustomed to thinking about how alternative media can be linked to voice, if voice is taken to be the "value that motivates the production of alternative media."[50] As we have already seen, alternative media are valued for their capacity to allow all kinds of individuals and groups to speak up, and by extension, for this communication to be potentially effective and to garner

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[45] Christian Fuchs, "Alternative Media as Critical Media," *European Journal of Social Theory* 13, no. 2 (2010): 189.

[46] Mowbray, "Alternative Logics," 22.

[47] Teal Triggs, "Liberated Spaces: Identity Politics and Anti-consumerism," in *Below Critical Radar: Fanzines and Alternative Comics from 1976 to Now*, ed. Roger Sabin and Teal Triggs (Slab-O-Concrete, 2002), 35.

[48] Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia* (University of Minnesota Press), 7.

[49] Nico Carpentier, Rico Lie, and Jan Servaes, "Community Media: Muting the Democratic Media Discourse?," *Continuum: Journal of Media and Cultural Studies* 17, no. 1 (2003): 61.

[50] Nick Couldry, "Alternative Media and Voice," in *The Routledge Companion to Alternative and Community Media*, ed. Chris Atton (Routledge, 2015), 44.

an audience. Couldry nudges us beyond this, "distinguishing between two levels: voice as a *process* (already relatively familiar) and voice as a *value*."[51]

This second level—voice as a value—becomes a crucial turning point for Couldry. Voice as a value "is particularly important at times when a whole way of thinking about social political and cultural organisation (neoliberalism) operates on the basis that for certain crucial purposes voice as a process does *not* matter."[52] Couldry pivots to argue in the affirmative, to say that "[t]reating voice as a value means discriminating in favor of ways of organizing human life and resources that put the value of voice into practice."[53] Couldry here draws on, and we point to, Clemencia Rodriguez's consideration of "citizens' media" as a touchstone for understanding voice as a value.[54] Rodriguez builds her case for citizens' media on how we ought not to think of "democracy as an ultimate goal, a final state-of-things to reach" but should instead consider "how democratic and nondemocratic forces are being renegotiated constantly, and how citizens' media can strengthen the former, thus contributing to the—although sometimes ephemeral—swelling of the democratic."[55] If we are to think of voice as a value in media processes, Rodriguez shows us what is being valued with her careful consideration of how citizens' media practitioners "may be relabeling the world, reorganizing reality, and reconstituting a new order where preestablished social and cultural codifications of power cease to make sense."[56] To value voice "then involves particular attention to the conditions under which voice *(as a process)* can be effective, and how broader forms of organization may subtly devalue voice,"[57] an operation that can be found in colonialism and postcolonialism as much as in neoliberalism. This is subtle work here, benefiting from the reflexivity that comes from both a healthy skepticism regarding presumed effects, and a deeper appreciation of the extent to which regnant modes of social organization can be understood as devaluing our voices. An appreciation of alternative media calls attention to that silencing.

Couldry develops some corollaries regarding the workings of voice. If voice can be defined as "our capacity to make, and be recognized as making, narratives about our lives and the world within which we act, some further general principles follow." The first of these is that "voice is socially grounded," and thus it "depends on shared material resources, and the specifically social resources (including language) that enable and sustain practices of narratives."[58] Second, we can come to understand that "voice is a form of reflexive agency." Our "exchangeable narratives" that come from our voices are not just "random babblings"; they represent "a form of agency for which we take responsibility as agents." Like other things we do, the "stories we tell, . . . as Hannah Arendt argues [in *The Human Condition]*, 'disclose'

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[51] Couldry, "Alternative Media and Voice," 44.

[52] Couldry, 44.

[53] Couldry, 44.

[54] We should point out that Rodriguez suggests that we "abandon the term 'alternative media' and coin a new marker: 'citizens' media.'" She sees "citizens' media" as superior because "'alternative media' rests on the assumption that these media are alternative to something, this definition will easily entrap us in binary thinking: mainstream media and their alternative, that is, alternative media." Clemencia Rodriguez, *Fissures in the Mediascape: An International Study of Citizens' Media* (Hampton Press, 2001), 20.

[55] Clemencia Rodriguez, *Fissures in the Mediascape*, 22.

[56] Rodriguez, 151.

[57] Couldry, "Alternative Media and Voice," 44.

[58] Couldry, 45.

us 'as subjects.'" The third and final corollary is that "voice requires a material form which may be individual, collective or distributed." [59] In addition to "social resources," voice also "requires a form. Both are aspects of the materiality of voice." Couldry points out that the "material form of voice need not be under the exclusive control of the individual." The media, including alternative media, give us many examples of situations—newspapers, movies, and streaming video/television are obvious examples—where voice is "collectively produced." Particularly important for the digital age is the fact that "sometimes we can recognize ourselves in the outcome of a production where specific individual and collective inputs cannot easily be separated from a broader flow: this form of voice is not individual or collective, but 'distributed.'" [60] Voice can thus be appreciated as a socially grounded form of reflexive agency that can be given material form, and can be individual, collective, or distributed.

Another important intervention in the conceptualization of alternative media comes from Wendy Willems, who recommends nothing less than "a shift from an analytical focus on 'alternative media' to 'alternative mediation.'" [61] This shift is largely derived from Jesús Martín-Barbero's efforts to de-center the familiar object of media studies ("the media" or "alternative media") and replace it with a focus on process instead. The focus on mediations, as Omar Rincón describes it, involves no longer "instrumentalizing media as carriers of information" so "we can begin to truly see media as traversed by interrelationships between popular culture, industrial machines, and politics." [62] Significantly, this emphasis on process over categorization in the context of alternative media shares a great deal with Clemencia Rodriguez's rejection of the term "alternative media" altogether, in favor of "citizens' media," a term that she believes will lead us away from merely categorizing different media outlets as "alternative" or not. [63] For Willems, this avoidance of labels helps her to analyze the media in Zimbabwe, where "Western-driven media" outlets—often backed by NGOs—found alternatives in both government-run media outlets and in "popular jokes . . . circulated in public spaces, through e-mail listservs and via SMS messages." [64] The meaningfully alternative approach to communication could be found to a great extent in government-run media outlets, which runs counter to many (Western) understandings of how alternative media operate. She judges the idea of mediation superior to alternative media, in part because mediation can take these kinds of relational dimensions to heart. "A key advantage of the concept of mediation," she writes, "is that it refers to the dynamic process of communication as compared to a more static understanding of institutions." [65] Willems thus helps us find a way out of the question-begging morass of determining what is and is not an alternative media outlet, so that we can instead find our way to the more essential—if more complicated because more dynamic—issue of

[59] Couldry, "Alternative Media and Voice," 46.

[60] Couldry, 46.

[61] Wendy Willems, "Alternative Mediation, Power and Civic Agency in Africa," in *The Routledge Companion to Alternative and Community Media*, ed. Chris Atton (Routledge, 2015), 90.

[62] Omar Rincón, "Martín-Barbero's Style," *Media, Culture & Society* 46, no. 3 (2024): 639.

[63] Rodriguez, *Fissures in the Mediascape*, 20.

[64] Willems, "Alternative Mediation," 94.

[65] Willems, 94. Here Willems draws on Jésus Martín-Barbero, *Communication, Culture and Hegemony: From the Media to Mediation* (Sage, 1993); Roger Silverstone, "The Sociology of Mediation and Communication," in *The Sage Handbook of Sociology*, ed. C. Calhoun, C. Rojek, and B. S. Turner (Sage, 2005); and Sonia Livingstone, "On the Mediation of Everything," *Journal of Communication* 59, no. 1 (2009).

how communication processes can be enacted as meaningful alternatives to dominant communication practices. None of this fully quells the debate regarding the effects of alternative media. It must be admitted that the capacity to effect massive influence is still largely the reserve of a relatively small number of large and usually state- or corporate-controlled media outlets. Nevertheless, this focus on mediation and on voice does help us to consider more fully the significance that alternative media can be understood to have.

Community Media

Where definitions of independent media are complex, definitions of community media in existing scholarship tend to to be more tightly circumscribed. These definitions are closely intertwined with the definitions of independent and alternative media outlined above. As with these other forms, community media are defined by the use of small-scale or non-commercial production and distribution networks. Like independent and alternative media, community media serve groups underrepresented or marginalized by commercial media, but importantly, community media prioritize questions of how underrepresented and marginalized communities can identify and attend to their own interests through local, accessible media networks.[66]

Definitions and considerations of community media tend to be more narrowly focused on practices of direct engagement. Chris Atton describes community media studies as being "primarily interested in social and cultural practices that enable people to participate directly in the organization, production and distribution of their own media" and which "are most often organized and produced by 'ordinary' people."[67] In this volume and across definitions of community media, the idea of "community" can address communities formed around shared interest, but the concept is most often defined geographically even as the form and function of community media can vary greatly.

While local interests may be lost in mainstream media, community media encourage direct engagement with their audiences and, in doing so, create spaces for community voices and community building. For audiences who feel "extreme dissatisfaction with mainstream media form and content," community media can provide avenues for "free expression and participatory democracy" that "enhanc[e] community relations and promot[e] community solidarity."[68] Ellie Rennie identifies both participation and access as distinctive qualities of community media which include "nonprofessional media makers" in production and "provid[e] individuals and community with a platform to express their views."[69] In some cases, involvement by community members goes beyond production to include management and policymaking. Community media serve an important function in providing opportunities for media makers to speak to and about the local communities to which they belong.

Even more than the other categories discussed in this volume, community media consider the democratizing potential of media—as tools that can develop civic identity and encourage

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[66] Peter M. Lewis, "Community Media Policy," in *The Routledge Companion to Alternative and Community Media*, ed. Chris Atton (Routledge, 2015), 179.

[67] Chris Atton, *The Routledge Companion to Independent and Alternative Media* (Routledge, 2015), 1.

[68] Kevin Howley, *Community Media: People, Places, and Communication Technologies* (Cambridge University Press, 2005), 2.

[69] Ellie Rennie, *Community Media: A Global Introduction* (Rowman & Littlefield, 2006), 3.

civic participation and as tools that are democratizing media production itself. As noted above, Clemencia Rodriguez defines a related category of locally-focused media she calls citizens' media. Where some studies of community media focus primarily on content, Rodriguez focuses on practice. By becoming active participants in citizens' media networks, as producers and as consumers, groups who are otherwise ignored or marginalized by existing media systems can become active citizens in their own communities. This category of community-focused media foregrounds empowerment as a central goal, encouraging citizens to "participate in actions that shape their own identities, the identities of others, and their social environment," and through doing so "produce power" within their communities.[70]

Access to the management and production of media often depends on the technical and financial demands of different media. Radio often attracts the attention of community media researchers as a result of radio's accessibility. Nick Jankowski argues that "because of the substantially less financial investment and operating costs [of radio] as compared to community television, community radio finds extensive application in development projects and among groups of resistance."[71] Various case studies highlight the importance of community radio platforms for resistance efforts.[72] Around the world, community radio has provided "a new communications paradigm" that shifts citizens' understanding of their own power and which can act as "a vehicle for marginalized communities to stake a claim in territory heretofore unquestionably ruled by the centre."[73] While radio is a powerful community-building tool, we see similar efforts by community TV stations[74]; digital community networks, online resources, and technology training centers[75]; and community filmmaking and film screenings.[76] Community media, then, come to be focused on building and maintaining direct connections to specific communities and are developed in order to serve those communities.

Pulling It All Together

A fundamental assumption that is broadly shared across definitions of IAC media holds that structural features of media organizations matter. This assumption, embraced also by critical political economists of the media, is frequently applied in critical understandings of

[70] Rodriguez, *Fissures in the Mediascape*, 19.

[71] Nicholas Jankowski, "Community Media Research: A Question for Theoretically-Grounded Models," *Javnost—The Public* 10, no. 1: 7.

[72] Patricia W. Elliott, "Another Radio is Possible: Thai Community Radio from the Grass Roots to the Global," *The Radio Journal: International Studies in Broadcast and Audio Media* 8, no. 1 (2010); Lawrence Naaikuur and Africanus L. Diedong, "Core Dimensions of Community Radio in Action: The Case of Ghana," *Global Media Journal: African Edition* 8, no. 2 (2014); Ian Watson, "Combatting Cultural 'Neve Gas': Maintaining Traditional Media and Culture Through Local Media Production in Australia, Canada and Mexico," *Journal of Alternative and Community Media* 2 (2017).

[73] Elliott, "Another Radio is Possible," 7.

[74] Lola de Koning, Elaine Nolten, and Koen Leurs, "Community Media Makers and the Mediation of Difference," in *Cultures, Citizenship, and Human Rights*, ed. Rosemarie Buikema, Antoine Buyse, and Antonius C.G.M. Robben (Routledge, 2020); Jankowski, "Community Media Research."

[75] Christina Dunbar-Hester, "Frailties at the Borders: Stalled Activist Media Projects in East Africa," *International Journal of Communication* 10 (2016); Jamie Alexander Greig, "Wireless Mesh Networks as Community Hubs: Analysis of Small-Scale Wireless Mesh Networks and Community-Centered Technology Training," *Journal of Information Policy* 8 (2018); Jankowski, "Community Media Research."

[76] Diana Coryat, "Not Just Surviving but Thriving: Practices That Sustain a New Generation of Latin American Community Media Makers," *Journal of Alternative and Community Media* 4, no. 4 (2019).

dominant media organizations—the small number of very large media firms that can reliably direct messages to very large numbers of people. This familiar political-economic critique of big media has been used to criticize these behemoths for undermining democracy, spreading imperialist ideologies, and operating counter to the needs of the public.[77] At the core of the arguments one finds an appreciation for how these dominant media organizations are, because of their size and influence, in many ways insulated from competition and aligned with other powerful forces, including other powerful capitalist entities and political elites. These organizations perpetuate themselves in large part not by responding to audience demand so much as by taking advantage of the benefits that accrue to established firms in twenty-first-century capitalism.[78] Economies of scale have long have long empowered dominant media to outcompete smaller entities, who must face choppier waves. Larger media corporations can plan further into the future, apply leverage more effectively to their competition and to other corporations with whom they collaborate, and take losses for a longer period of time than smaller operations. Larger media corporations can benefit from easier access to finance and to investors' massive troves of wealth. Because their operations are so well-financed, they inevitably develop strategies in media production that are focused on reducing risk, which leads to a reliance on formulaic and proven media products. Risk reduction is often paired with a drive to extend media corporations globally. This risk-reduced sameness becomes a significant chunk of what passes for global culture, undermining local cultures and advancing the interests of the powerful. In broad strokes, dominant media corporations are criticized for operating in a top-down manner: These are large organizations operating hierarchically within themselves and acting to preserve and control their own very powerful positions. While one might hope that such large and well-positioned media firms would have the spine to stand up to, say, authoritarian tendencies in twenty-first-century politics, we find more frequently that the dominant media firms remain too committed to their own interests in profit and risk reduction to justify much hope in their advocacy on behalf of democracy.

Much as the structural analysis of these dominant media organizations lends itself to a critical understanding of their roles in society, a structural understanding of IAC media shows us that "structures" in and of themselves are not the problem. IAC media operate separately from the dominant media and are as a rule much smaller in scale. They may or may not be profit-oriented. Almost without exception they are not publicly traded companies; one cannot buy stock in them. IAC media are accessible in a way that dominant media are not; they can

[77] Classics of the genre in the US and UK include: Ben Bagdikian, *The Media Monopoly* (Beacon Press, 1983); Robert W. McChesney, *Telecommunications, Mass Media, and Democracy: The Battle for Control of U.S. Broadcasting, 1928–1935* (Oxford University Press, 1993); Jeremy Tunstall, *The Media are American: Anglo-American Media in the World* (Columbia University Press, 1979); and Herbert I. Schiller, *Mass Communications and American Empire* (Beacon Press, 1971).

[78] The issue of supply and demand is—or should be—a complicated one in media studies. We hold that dominant media firms enjoy a position whereby their offerings come to be so ubiquitous that the very idea of demand becomes complicated. To turn this on its head, imagine a very small-scale publication, perhaps one that is printed in an edition of five copies. If someone found this and bought it, that would seem to be a more "demand"-originated moment of consumption than when someone elects to engage with media texts produced and distributed by dominant media firms. To be an audience member for something made by a dominant media firm is not much of a choice. It is more likely to be the result of habit, or of surrender. Descriptions of active audiences often miss the point that even the ability to gain access to some texts is unevenly distributed, and that texts do not require tremendous activity on the part of the audience (though they may be subject to all kinds of audience initiative).

be flexible, and they can be approached from without, as when an audience member demands explanation. In this sense, IAC media operate in a bottom-up manner, without substantial power in their respective markets and with less assurance that they can be sustained for very long. We have already seen Nick Couldry and James Curran's definition of alternative media as challenging the concentration of media power.[79] With media power concentrated in the hands of the (very) few, IAC media, simply by operating, come to be part of something "other than" what dominant media offer. IAC media are thus taken to be valuable because they can give the world something other than, something in implicit opposition to, what the dominant media do. They are structurally impelled to be something different. While dominant media operate according to logics of centralization and risk avoidance, IAC media operate according to a logic of diversification, and this puts them in a very risky business, where their operations are never too big to fail.

The existence and sustenance of IAC media in many cases depends on structures in place to preserve them. IAC media need: material resources (including a place to operate and technical equipment), means of generating funds, outlays of time available for media production and distribution, human capital (including all kinds of know-how and on-the-ground skills), social capital (personal connections between members of IAC media organizations and connections to the world around them), and some kind of meaningful linkage to the surrounding culture so that the content they purvey can claim some relevance. Given the tendencies of dominant media, we can see how IAC outlets benefit from low barriers to entry. When it is not extremely expensive to create and distribute media, it is easier for IAC media to operate. Zines are a classic example. Zines (short for "fanzines") are small-scale publications, distributed via mail order or in specialty stores. One reasons zines came into being and still exist is that they are very inexpensive to make. Access to a photocopier, a stapler, and a pen are frequently all that is technically required. This accessibility can be contrasted with broadcast television, in which even a single episode requires far more resources. This expense contrast is instructive for this reader, because it helps to highlight a theme that is often implicit: IAC media are frequently created and sustained when barriers to entry are low.

Much of the difference between IAC media and dominant media is brought out by Pierre Bourdieu's concepts of autonomy and heteronomy in cultural production. The value of autonomy—implied in such phrases as "creative control," "freedom of expression," and even "independent media," "alternative media," and "community media"—is connected to the situation where those who are making the culture are not beholden to or restricted by "outside" forces. Bourdieu describes the "field of restricted production," where "the field of large-scale production . . . is symbolically excluded,"[80] and where the "opposition between the 'commercial' and the 'non-commercial'" comes to be important.[81] This sense of exemption from large-scale production clears the way for a certain autonomy, a concern for something other than profit-oriented goals that are imposed from above. It is easy to go too far with a word like "autonomy"; for our purposes all that matters is that individuals involved in making IAC media are, as a rule, operating according to logics distinct from those that inform dominant media. Also implied here is the idea that IAC media are not isolated from dominant media;

[79] Couldry and Curran, "Introduction and Theoretical Perspectives," 7.

[80] Pierre Bourdieu, *The Field of Cultural Production* (Columbia University Press, 1993), 39.

[81] Bourdieu, *The Field of Cultural Production*, 82.

they are, instead, relationally identified in terms of how they make links to each other and in terms of how they differ from dominant media.[82] Another implication of this understanding of IAC media is that they can frequently be susceptible to certain types of exclusion, to creating symbolic barriers that keep some people out. Exclusion can be a welcome feature for those hoping to breathe life into a subcultural formation. The quality of being set aside from the broader culture can allow marginal groups to thrive. Of course that drive for exclusivity can also reproduce longstanding power relations around race, class, gender, sexuality, language, and more. Simply being set aside from the mainstream is no guarantee that the culture in question challenges dominant power relations. The dream of a world where everyone gets relatively equal access to the media is quite familiar, and this dream is often applied to new media technologies. When the World Wide Web became popular in the 1990s, there was considerable hope that we would all benefit from the enhanced power to create content alongside a dramatically increased range of content to receive. What actually transpired, of course, has been quite different. The web has become a welcoming home for finance-backed corporations accumulating user bases, where the asymmetries in media production have reasserted themselves. The financialization of media—including, but not limited to, the internet—has rearranged much of what we think of as "media industries" and drawn even large companies into strange new terrain inhospitable to variety and to the interests of smaller audiences.[83] Part of this can be understood in terms of Cory Doctorow's concept of "enshittification," which refers to the process by which companies doing business on the web come to place less and less emphasis on individual users or audience members as they focus more on other businesses as customers and then move on to investors.[84] The finance-intensive world of twenty-first-century media processes is rife with this kind of thing. *We suggest that IAC media can be thought of as unshittified media.*[85] They are definitively aimed at and put into conversation with audience members more than they are shaped by the interests of other businesses or shareholders. This reader can serve as a reminder that media can be put into service of the needs and desires of people.

How This Reader Was Assembled

The process of gathering material for the reader was marked by care and critical reflection. We set out to find as many article-length sources as possible. Such a list would, after careful scrutiny, provide the bedrock from which we could extract a volume that fit our interests. We began with databases and search engines such as EBSCO, ProQuest, Google Scholar, and Nexis Uni. We employed a variety of search terms that reflect the diverse IAC nomenclature: indie media, indy media, independent media, alternative media, grassroots media, activist

[82] For an excellent critical take on Bourdieu's notion of autonomy in the media—and especially in journalism—see Michael Schudson, "Autonomy from What?," in *Bourdieu and the Journalistic Field*, ed. Rodney Benson and Erik Neveu (Polity, 2005).

[83] See Andrew DeWaard, *Derivative Media: How Wall Street Devours Culture* (University of California Press, 2024).

[84] Cory Doctorow, "How Monopoly Enshittified Amazon," *Pluralistic: Daily Links from Cory Doctorow*, November 28, 2022.

[85] With sadness, we acknowledge that in many cases they just haven't been enshittified yet . . . Still we see great value in appreciating both the lack of attention to audience demand found amongst dominant media and the often very direct relationship with audiences found in IAC media.

media, community media, and participatory media. We then added medium-specific search terms ("comic books," "movies," "radio," and so on). We found thousands of candidate sources.

This is an *open* reader, so we winnowed out paywalled materials by focusing exclusively on those that are open access (OA). Here the sorting was, at times, difficult. Many publishers—especially from the dominant media—are intentionally unclear about permissions and copyright status. After checking and re-checking, we narrowed the list of thousands down to 284 OA academic texts.

We then began the hard work of selecting the pieces that fill this reader. We carefully weighed each source, guided by a vision of the kind of reader we want to use ourselves. Here are the criteria we used:

1. ***Relevance.*** Is the source centrally occupied with issues pertaining to IAC media? Or does it only touch fleetingly on the concept?
2. ***Recency.*** Does the source connect with themes that remain relevant today, in 2026? Would its inclusion in a course syllabus make the reader more relevant to undergraduate and graduate students today? Or is it primarily focused on issues that do not leave much to consider in our time?
3. ***Variety.*** Does the source, acting in concert with other sources, add something new to the conversation, something that diverges both from what students can be assumed to already know, and from what other sources in the reader have to offer?
4. ***Conceptual heft.*** Does the source identify concepts that give students and instructors tools for understanding IAC media more broadly? Can the source be put into sympathetic or antagonistic conversation with other items in the reader and elsewhere in a curriculum? Or does the source simply identify isolated parts of what could be a bigger story?
5. ***Inclusion:*** Does the source push the reader away from a reliance on issues coming out of the Global North and specifically from dominant parts of the social formations in the Global North? Is the subject matter or theoretical center of gravity inclined toward demonstrating the relevance of IAC media to oft-excluded groups? [86]

As we identified the texts, we also kept our eyes on the connections among them. We identified categories of texts as they occurred in literature searches. This allowed us to identify eleven sections for this reader:

[86] There is much to be said about how our quarry here—the world of open access articles and books—is capable of a deceptive exclusion. In many ways this mirrors the kinds of exclusion that Mohan Dutta et al. find at work in open science, where the broader rhetoric of "openness," supported by meaningful work to make data available to other researchers, comes to reperform norms of whiteness and Eurocentrism. A similar dynamic can be found in open access, where the open access itself conceals a situation where the availability and viability of open access as a practice is unevenly distributed, with strong power centers in Western Europe, the UK, and the US. It is worth pointing out that Latin American scholars have established meaningful inroads to open access (and one can detect the fruits of this important work by Latin American scholars and journals in this reader). See Mohan Dutta et al., "Decolonizing Open Science: Southern Interventions," *Journal of Communication* 71, no. 5 (2021).

6. ***Conceptualizing Independent, Alternative, and Community Media.*** This section features sources that address fundamental theoretical concerns regarding what IAC media are, how they can be identified, and why they matter.[87]
7. ***History, Memory, and Archives.*** Here we have gathered sources that highlight how IAC media are subject to historical forces, and how they can be linked to efforts to tie together collective memory.
8. ***Policy, Regulations, and Government Intervention.*** It would be wrong to presume that IAC media exist in a state of magical autonomy. The sources in this section demonstrate the often-subtle connections between IAC media and policies that threaten, protect, sustain, or weaken them.
9. ***Production and Distribution.*** The question of how media programming comes to be made and made accessible to audience members is of central importance to all discussion of IAC media. This section includes sources that highlight this part of the media process.
10. ***Labor, Funding, and Promotion.*** This section pulls together sources that deal with the micro-level concerns that confront those who work in the world of IAC media. These outlets could not exist without the work to sustain them through funding, promotion, and other forms of labor.
11. ***Messages, Narratives, and Representations.*** Though structural elements are often used to identify and define IAC media, it is important to consider how different orders of signification and meaning come to be associated with IAC media. What meanings are generated via IAC media? This section is populated with sources that give us answers to that question.
12. ***Audiences: Participation, Engagement, and Access.*** IAC media must be considered in terms of their audiences. Here we have gathered sources that explore and chronicle the activities of IAC media audiences, and how these activities come to matter.
13. ***Journalism and the Public.*** The significance of IAC media in helping to summon a public into existence is a major concern in much IAC media scholarship, and this section features articles that consider this process in a variety of contexts.
14. ***Community and Localism.*** In this section we feature sources that are largely concerned with how IAC media come to relate to space, and to the sustenance of local cultures. If dominant media are largely focused on global expansion, it should come as little surprise that IAC media can be described in terms of how they perform localism.
15. ***Networks and Social Media.*** The place of IAC media vis-à-vis the internet can be difficult to chart. The sources gathered in this section consider how issues related to internet-based media, including everything from social networking platforms to simple web content to actual internet networks themselves, can be connected to IAC media.
16. ***Activism and Resistance.*** Though other sections in this reader touch upon important issues related to politics and the public, we found numerous sources concerned primarily with activism

[87] We wish to acknowledge that, despite our efforts to be inclusive in as many ways as possible in our choices, this section tends to reproduce a global divide between a Western world that is thought of as capable of high-level theoretical work and the rest of the world, where theoretical work is often (very wrongly) thought not to be done. See Wendy Willems, "Provincializing Hegemonic Histories of Media and Communication Studies: Toward a Genealogy of Epistemic Resistance in Africa," *Communication Theory* 24, no. 4 (2014).

and related forms of direct political action. This section is dedicated to sources that attend to grassroots political efforts aimed at some form of direct action via IAC media.

As evidenced by the size and breadth of this reader—with its seventy-six sources across eleven thematic sections—we opted to err on the side of inclusion. We see this as entirely consistent with our own goals as instructors, and with the goals we envision for students. There are lots of ways to learn about IAC media. We hope we have provided a number of avenues for exploring this essential terrain.

Conclusion

We close by pointing out that this open reader has been published by an IAC media outlet, mediastudies.press. mediastudies.press is a community-supported, scholar-led, Diamond OA press (where one of us serves as co-director). Our process of assembling the reader has been in keeping with some familiar themes from IAC media discussed here and in the rest of the reader. Our work has been conducted in a manner that was independent from non-scholarly impulses, and the work is an alternative to volumes published by much larger presses. Perhaps most importantly, the reader represents an attempt to serve a community of scholars and students. It is always a good time to remember that classroom and scholarly communities are mediatized spaces, and this reader's construction drew inspiration from scholars curious about IAC media as well as from a range of IAC media workers around the world.

This open reader includes seventy-six entries. By any standard, this is a *lot* of content. We see this as justified first because we are casting a net over independent, alternative, and community media. This is an ambitious scope for any collection. Another justification for including so much material is that it allows us to demonstrate that there is a lot of high-quality open access scholarly work on this topic. An apparent bug—the wide range of selections, far too large for any single semester's syllabus—is, for us, a feature. We hope that this reader will lend itself to diverse classroom applications, and the abundance of content should give instructors and students more options, more points of contact, than a more tightly curated volume would.

Finally, we hope that this collection can become yet another powerful demonstration of the value of the open reader. Open educational resources (OERs) are already reasonably well established in the academy, but if any topic deserves a powerful demonstration of the utility of an OER, it is IAC media.

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